XIV—The Lonely Immortal

> ‘When I came to India I was much attracted by the elephants, and I thought that the use of their extraordinary strength was a prognostication of my universal ascendency.’
>
> – Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

One of Akbar’s many acts of public charity was to establish ‘two places for feeding poor Hindus and Musalmans’ and a third for feeding yogis. It was with this third group that Akbar once celebrated Shivratri, eating and drinking with some of the principal ascetics, who predicted that the emperor would ‘live three or four times as long as ordinary men’.[1]

‘Fawning court doctors, wisely enough, found proofs of the longevity of the Emperor,’ Badauni continues; they even hailed the beginning of a new age, in which the ‘original longevity of mankind’ – there were books that said that men once lived 1000 years – ‘would again commence’. Even now, ascetics in Tibet and China could live as long as two centuries.

Death – and its avoidance – was becoming one of Akbar’s obsessions. The emperor who had ridden musth elephants across bobbing and sliding pontoon bridges, gambling on God’s opinion with his life, now began to practise ascetic disciplines that might help him put off his own demise – celibacy and a vegetarian diet amongst them.[2] Even when death came, as death must, Akbar would not cease to exist: he shaved the crown of his head, from which ‘he believed that the soul of perfect beings’ escaped when they died, making a sound like thunder, which ‘the dying man may look upon as a proof of his happiness and salvation from sin, and as a sign that his soul

. . . will pass into the body of some grand and mighty king’.[3]

Badauni, always a little disparaging of what he thought of as Akbar’s susceptibility to outrageous ideas, writes that the emperor ‘fully believed’ all that he was told about his longevity. If that is so, if Akbar was convinced by, say, Fathullah Shirazi’s forecast that he would live over 120 years, he was also determined, it seems, to fill every unforgiving minute of his long life with frenetic activity.

In October 1583, a few months after Fathullah arrived in his court and a